

NIHONKAI MONTANE FOREST

A hilly ecoregion that experiences harsh winters

This deciduous forest ecoregion covers 31,800 sq miles (82,300 sq km) of the mountainous backbone of Japan's main island, Honshu, and a small portion of the more northerly island of Hokkaido. Two-thirds of Japan is covered with forest, although only a quarter is original, or primary, natural forest; the rest is secondary forest or plantations. Japan has a total of seven different natural forest ecoregions, including several evergreen and deciduous types and subtropical moist forest.

Wet summers, snowy winters

The Nihonkai montane forest is characterized by trees, shrubs, and grasses that flourish in warm, wet summers and then shed their leaves to survive throughout cold, snowy winters. The most numerous deciduous tree in the Nihonkai ecoregion is the Japanese cherry, which is now widely cultivated as an ornamental in parks and gardens

around the world. Other trees typically found in the forests include Japanese beech, katsura, and Japanese hornbeam. Many forest animals feed on the nuts and fruits produced by the trees, and so play an important role in dispersing their seeds.

In addition to the montane forest's canopy of mature full-sized trees, there is a lower layer of trees that are yet to reach full size, a shrub layer, and an understory of grasses and herbs. Biodiversity is greatest near the forest floor, unlike in tropical rainforests, where the number of species is highest in the canopy. The most iconic animal of the Nihonkai forest is the Japanese macaque.



POPULATION BOOM
More than 100,000 sika deer are estimated to live in Japan. Their numbers have boomed since the extinction of their main predator, the gray wolf, around a century ago. They are now considered a pest in their natural forest habitat and on farmland.

SIKA DEER

TRANSIENT BEAUTY
The Japanese cherry, or sakura, has profuse but short-lived displays of white or pink blossoms in spring. To the Japanese, their temporary beauty symbolizes the ephemeral nature of life and is celebrated in the hanami, or flower viewing, festival.

CHERRY BLOSSOM

One of seven forest ecoregions in Japan

Japanese cherry is the most common deciduous

SEASONAL DIET
One of the most widespread and abundant birds in Japan, the white-eye is seldom seen on the ground. It forages in trees and shrubs, searching for insects in summer and berries in fall, and feeding on blossoms, particularly cherry, in spring.